

To: Dr. Maksym Andriushchenko

Email: maksym.andriushchenko@uni-tuebingen.de

Subject: Application for Prospective PhD — AI Safety & Alignment Group — Nauval Zulfikar

Dear Dr. Andriushchenko,

I am writing to express my interest in joining the AI Safety & Alignment Group at the ELLIS Institute Tübingen / Max Planck Institute for Intelligent Systems as a prospective PhD candidate. I am particularly drawn to the group's focus on AI safety and alignment, adversarial robustness, and trustworthy machine learning, which align closely with my academic background and research interests. I am available to start on 1 September 2026.

Your paper, *[TODO: verify supervisor paper title via Google Scholar]*, has been instrumental in shaping my understanding of the challenges and opportunities in AI safety. The depth of analysis and innovative approaches presented in your work inspire me to contribute to this critical field.

During my MSc in Business Analytics at Aston University, I engaged in projects that resonate with the themes of your research group. Notably, my MSc dissertation, *"Enhancing Supply Chain Information Sharing Systems Through Blockchain: Integrated Customer Reviews LLM Analysis: A Smart Contract Approach"*, involved fine-tuning the DeBERTa-v3 transformer for multi-tier supplier review data, which parallels the need for robust and trustworthy AI systems. Additionally, my project on *LLM-Generated Adaptive Shipper Decision Rules* utilised an end-to-end RAG system with gpt-4o-mini, focusing on reproducibility and ablation, which aligns with the group's emphasis on trustworthy ML.

I acknowledge that my background in Business Analytics may present a gap compared to a pure Computer Science or Machine Learning focus. However, my experience in data science roles, including as a Data Scientist & Project Manager at the Public Works & Spatial Planning Department, has equipped me with practical skills in model validation, governance, and infrastructure, which are essential for advancing AI safety.

I have attached my CV and a one-page research statement for your review. I am eager to discuss how my background, skills, and interests align with the goals of your research group.

Sincerely,

Nauval Zulfikar

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